

The Rainmaker

"Amma, is it wrong to do something that will make us happy?" Vijay asked his mother, sitting on the **edge** of the bed and chewing a mango bar slowly.

Amma, who was folding his clothes and putting them into a suitcase, looked up at him. He was looking at her with that expression which meant that he was trying to **figure out** something. She put his T-shirt aside and sat next to him.

"It's not wrong for us to want to be happy, my child," she said, running her hand through his hair. "But it is wrong to be happy by making someone else sad."

Vijay paused in the middle of his chewing as he tried to **work out** in his mind what his mother had said. Then as if he had **reached some conclusion** of his own, he **shook his head**, finished the last bit of the bar in one **gulp** and stood up.

"Ok, Amma, I'll go say goodbye to my cousins," he said and ran away.

Vijay and his parents had come to his grandmother's village two weeks back as his grandmother was very ill. He had spent every minute he could with his grandmother though her **trembling** hands and **pale** face **frightened** him.

Then one evening when they were alone, she pulled him close and **whispered** in his ear, "My time is up, Vijay and I want you to be the rainmaker from now on. Our village needs rain. Go to the banyan tree at the edge of the village and say these words aloud:

Rain **in vain** we wait. Come now, come flow. Turn our land into green gold."

Vijay was thrilled. He couldn't believe that his grandmother had appointed him as THE rainmaker!

For centuries, someone or the other from his family had been the rainmaker. His parents had **often wondered** who would become the rainmaker after grandmother **passed away**.

Vijay couldn't wait to return to the city. It hadn't rained there since the summer holidays and Vijay badly wanted the city to get some rain. He loved playing in the rain with his friends, jumping in **puddles** and **splashing** water with his bicycle.

He remembered his grandmother's warning,

"Use the gift well, Vijay. And remember, you can call the rains only once every year. Use it well for your people."



At the time he had felt as though his grandmother had given him his favorite ice cream and then told him not to eat it.

"But I want rain in the city," he thought **in dismay**. "I want to play in the rain!"

Vijay and his parents got into the car and his dad drove slowly through the village. They had left all the houses behind and there were open fields on either side. Vijay saw an old man leading two cows; he was headed out of the village like they were.

"Amma," said Vijay, "where do you think he is taking the cows?"

"Probably to the **butchers**," she said, **barely giving** the cows and the man **a second look**. "Because of this **drought**, he can't **feed** them and has to sell them to get whatever money he can."

Vijay's throat went dry. He hadn't known that people sold their cattle during a drought.

A few minutes later, Vijay saw a woman with two very young girls carrying buckets on their heads. The girls looked tired and **miserable**.

"Amma," Vijay said again, "where do you think they are coming from?"

"From the neighbouring village **perhaps**. The poor women have to walk for miles and miles to get water to drink. At least, we don't have that problem in the city."

As the last of the fields gave way, Vijay saw a puja being performed in the middle of a field that was dry and cracked.

"Appa, look!" he pointed, "They are having a celebration."

"No, Vijay," his father said. "When there have been no rains in a long time, the villagers here perform a wedding ceremony for frogs. They believe that it will bring rains."

Vijay knew from the tone of his father's voice that he didn't believe in what the people were doing.

"Appa," said Vijay as they reached the banyan tree that **marked** the village boundary. "Can you please stop by the banyan tree?"

His father looked at him curiously, but stopped near the tree. Vijay got down from the car, took off his shoes and leaving them in the car, he walked across the dry earth and stood in the shade of the tree. He could see that the banyan tree itself was beginning to die from the drought.



He closed his eyes, thought of his grandmother, and repeated the words she had told him:

"Rain in vain we wait. Come now, come flow. Turn our land into green gold."

For a few minutes, nothing happened. Vijay thought he had failed.

Then just as he was walking back to the car, he felt the first drops of rain fall on his eyelashes and on his head.

@mocks_wallah

Vocabulary

1. **Edge** (noun) – border, boundary, rim, fringe, margin किनारा
2. **Figure out** (phrasal verb) – understand, solve, decode, determine, comprehend समझना
3. **Work out** (phrasal verb) – resolve, figure out, calculate, decipher, conclude हल करना / निकालना
4. **Reach conclusion** (phrase) – decide, determine, infer, deduce, arrive at निष्कर्ष पर पहुँचना
5. **Shake one's head** (phrase) – express disagreement, refuse, deny, reject, negate सिर हिलाकर मना करना
6. **Gulp** (noun) – swallow, mouthful, draught, swig, sip घूँट
7. **Trembling** (adjective) – shaking, quivering, shivering, wavering, unsteady कांपता हुआ
8. **Pale** (adjective) – colorless, wan, faded, dull, light पीला / मुरझाया हुआ
9. **Frighten** (verb) – scare, terrify, alarm, startle, unnerve डराना
10. **Whisper** (verb) – murmur, speak softly, mutter, hiss, breathe फुसफुसाना
11. **In vain** (phrase) – uselessly, fruitlessly, to no effect, unsuccessfully, pointlessly व्यर्थ
12. **Often** (adverb) – frequently, regularly, repeatedly, commonly, usually अक्सर
13. **Wonder** (verb) – think, ponder, speculate, question, consider आश्चर्य करना / विचार करना
14. **Pass away** (phrasal verb) – die, expire, depart, perish, succumb मृत्यु होना
15. **Puddle** (noun) – small pool, water patch, splash, wet spot, pool पानी का छोटा गड्ढा
16. **Splash** (verb) – scatter, spray, spatter, sprinkle, slosh पानी उछालना
17. **In dismay** (phrase) – with sadness, in disappointment, gloomily, hopelessly, sorrowfully निराशा में
18. **Butcher** (noun) – meat seller, slaughterer, meat vendor, animal killer, meat cutter कसाई
19. **Barely** (adverb) – hardly, scarcely, just, only, narrowly मुश्किल से / केवल
20. **Give someone the second look** (phrase) – ignore, not notice again, overlook, pay no attention, disregard दुबारा न देखना / ध्यान न देना
21. **Drought** (noun) – dry spell, lack of rain, aridity, dryness, rainlessness सूखा
22. **Feed** (verb) – nourish, give food, sustain, supply, provide खिलाना

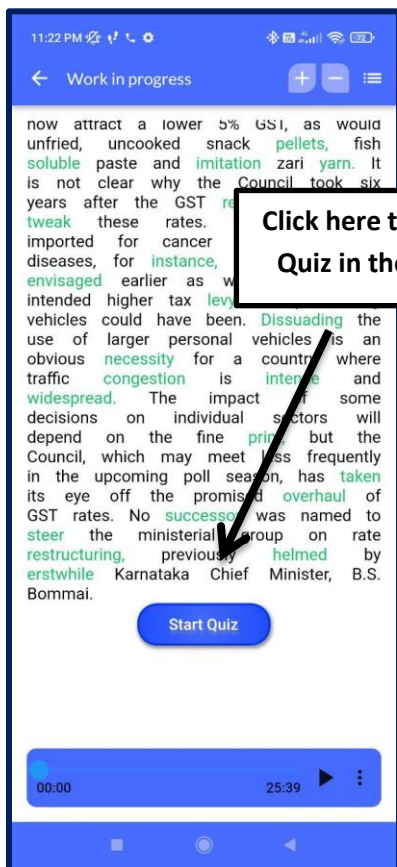
23. **Miserable** (adjective) – unhappy, sad,
gloomy, depressed, dejected दुखी / परेशान

25. **Mark** (verb) – indicate, signify, denote,
identify, highlight चिह्नित करना

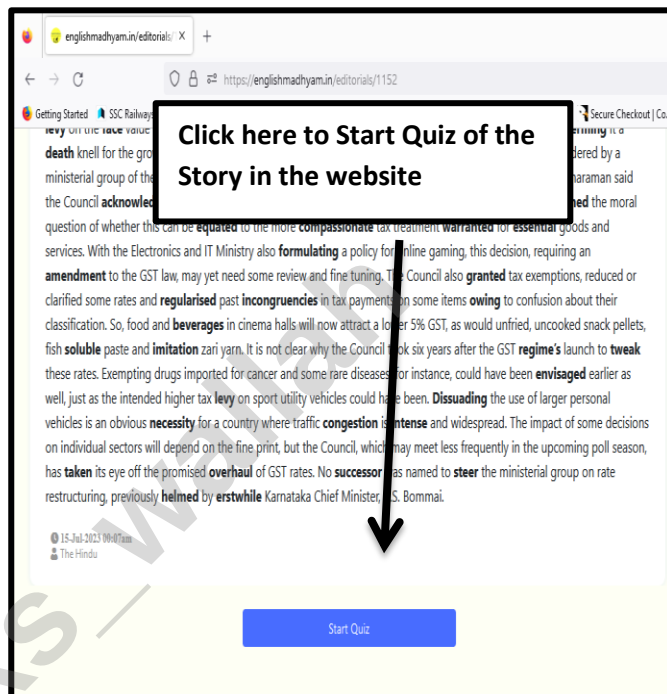
24. **Perhaps** (adverb) – maybe, possibly,
probably, conceivably, perchance शायद

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Practice Exercise



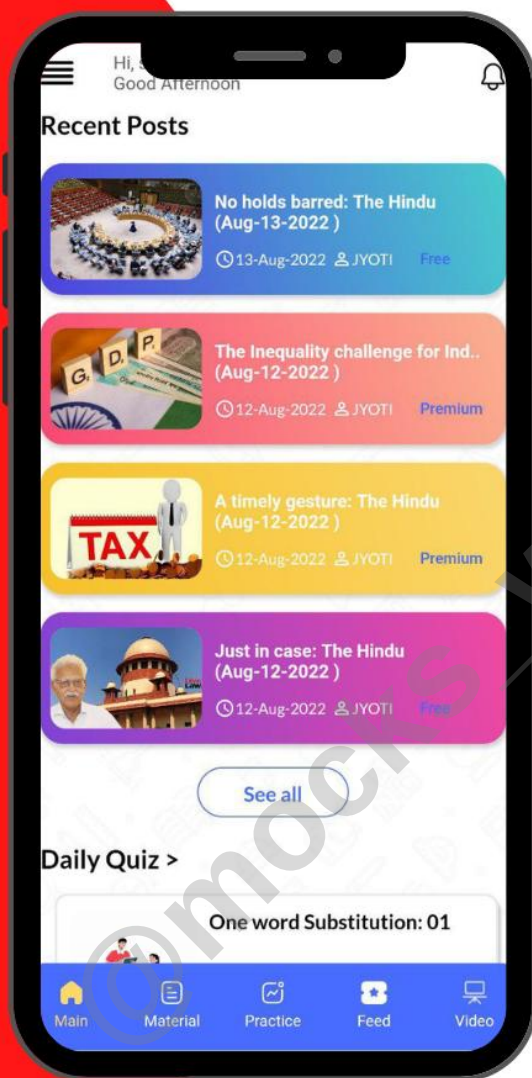
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